

The social media campaign I am going to describe and analyse is Shot on iPhone 2023 Campaign. This campaign is really direct and easy: Apple encourages users worldwide to post their photos and videos using hashtags like #ShotoniPhone, #ShotoniPhone2023, and location-based tags (e.g., #ShotoniPhoneTokyo). These hashtags allow Apple to discover high-quality UGC for potential reposts, and Apple continuously selects outstanding user-generated photos and videos to feature on its official Instagram page or in regional social campaigns. What's more, Apple occasionally selects emerging creators and features their stories on Instagram or YouTube—explaining how they shot their content using only an iPhone (See Appendix A).

This serious campaign is Apple's long-term global brand campaign, and first launched in 2015, so it has been ongoing for more than 9 years until now. According to the article from Apple's official website in 2019, the goal of this campaign is "inviting iPhone photographers from around the world to share their best shots". The core objective of this campaign is "make the iPhone a photography tool in everyone's hands, and capture images worthy of display".

The shot on iPhone campaign is Apple's way of highlighting iPhone's camera capabilities by inviting users and professionals to shoot with iPhone and share their work, thus turning everyday moments into show-stopping visuals. Based on tiered target audience model and combined with the goal of Shot on iPhone, the target audience are the normal people who just like taking photograph by iPhone. Because we can know that Apple did not claim that its mobile phone cameras could compete with professional cameras, nor did it require users to have high-level photography skills. This activity aims to reach out to a wider audience, as

mentioned above, the entry requirements for participation are very low, the process of shooting is not complicated, and uploading photos is something that almost everyone can do.

When it comes to the communicating effect, the core target audience and primary audience of Shot on iPhone campaign also included a large amount group of people, for example, vloggers, TikTok and Instagram creators, and filmmakers. Because the pictures create by these people have more opportunities to effect more people and they have acquired more shooting skills, making it easier to get more attractive photos with an iPhone. The context of this campaign included many aspects, one of the most direct factors is that Apple has launched new products. According to Apple (2023), in 2023 Apple launched the iPhone 15 Pro/iPhone 15 Pro Max. Its camera system supports ProRes 4K 60fps, Log color encoding, and professional post-production processes. Another one is Competitive and differentiation environment. Rather than just selling specs, Apple leverages this campaign to position iPhone as a creative tool and lifestyle statement. According to Forbes (2023) “The campaign is about selling dreams to someone who has picked up an iPhone and wants to do something.”

There are different activities every year, over the years of these activities, I believe that the most exciting one was in 2023. The most important and obvious are the Hashtag, users engagement and the choice of platform. According to Naraine (2021), brand-oriented hashtags can "gather" users into the same context, thereby forming a brand community. Hashtag is a place where users jointly create meaning, rather than a brand-exclusive promotional slogan. Apple use a long-term branded hashtag (#ShotOniPhone) to organize a global user community. They encourage global UGC uploading across Instagram, TikTok, X using the same hashtag, design platform-native prompts (such as micro-film themes,

photography challenges) to encourage users from different cultures to participate. It allows users to co-create the brand meaning around #ShotOniPhone. When users click and enter #ShotOniPhone, they can see the pictures shot by other people, this is not just about seeing the photos taken by others, but also about seeing the world through others' eyes. Because this hashtag can gather all the images from this campaign and it is a global event, so it will significantly enhance Apple's user retention and community interaction all over the world. As for the user engagement, Apple really knows how to facilitate it. Apple collaborated with celebrities from various regions to produce films, such as Park Chan-wook (see appendix B), John Lie Ning, Jolie Chen, Blackpink, Hurricane, etc. These celebrities come from different countries, covering different industries including entertainment and film. They represent China, Europe, USA and South Korea, as well as different styles like K-pop, rock, and pop. This strategy can maximize the coverage of fans from different dimensions, engaging them and enhancing user participation. When it comes to the choice of platform, according to De Kloet (2005) and Zhao (2021), the platform ecosystem is composed of various platform cultures. Each platform has its own values, operational logic, algorithmic system and user norms. For Instagram, major of the users are young female (Singh, Halgamuge and Moses, 2019), the platform places great emphasis on aesthetics, and it has long advocated a visual culture characterized by cleanliness and aesthetic consistency, so Apple on Instagram has turned #ShotOniPhone2023 into a "global photo exhibition", featuring selected submissions from users worldwide. In terms of TikTok, the culture of TikTok centers around remixing and short-video entertainment. The users are the Z Generation, who prefer content that can be "copyable actions". The culture of TikTok is not about watching, but about doing. Apple has

released a large number of 10-20 second "photography techniques": light placement, transitions, panning shots, Cinematic mode, and collaborate with film creators and allow users to recreate "film shot challenges". Concerning YouTube, this platform offers long viewing sessions, 4K, immersive content. Its users are movie enthusiasts, tech fans, and professional creators. Apple collaborates with directors to produce film-quality short films (such as Park Chan-wook and Chen Kexin), and simultaneously uploads behind-the-scenes footage and technical explanations (lighting, camera movement, ProRes). The last one is Weibo, This platform has a strong trend-following culture. It focuses on hot events, celebrity collaborations, and technological releases. The user habits on different platforms also lead to variations in the interaction rate: interaction rates on different platforms: Instagram approximately 3.8%, TikTok approximately 5.2%, Twitter/X approximately 1.1%, YouTube approximately 2.3% (Jeremias and Zhang 2025). Therefore, Apple's strategy is to invite celebrity directors, release short videos, quickly climb the trending list, and have official media and technology media report simultaneously to enhance its authority.

This campaign is really successful in my opinion, based on the theory from Peters et al. (2013), S – O – R is a good way to reflect the effective of the campaign, especially R (Response). According to Chapman (2023) from Infegy, since January 2022, the "interaction" (likes + shares + comments) volume of this activity has increased by approximately 140%. #ShotOniPhone has approximately 28.9 million posts on Instagram. When we compare horizontally with Samsung, Samsung also has its own brand campaign related to photography, with UGC (user-generated content), but the topic tags and visual styles update relatively quickly, and it may not be able to form a fixed visual theme like #ShotOniPhone that has

persisted for nearly a decade (Shastri 2025). Compared with other mobile phone brands or data-related activities, the advantage of "Shot on iPhone" lies in the "sustainability" and "accumulability" of user-generated content. It does not change the label every year, but continuously updates the themes and gameplay under the same main label, allowing user content to accumulate over time, strengthening Apple's long-term connection with "image culture". Compared with the activities in previous years and the earlier stage that mainly focused on static photos, Shot on iPhone in 2023 is more like an "image production infrastructure": it includes both the daily creations of ordinary users and the event-related video content and product launch presentations of brand levels. Looking at it longitudinally, it has achieved an upgrade from "selecting good photos" to "completing the entire content production process with an iPhone".

However, this activity is not without any drawbacks, this activity also has some controversial points. According to Weatherbed (2023): the "Scary Fast" release by Apple will be officially emphasized as "shot on iPhone 15 Pro Max". However, upon delving into the behind-the-scenes details, it was discovered that this entire press conference was made possible through the use of a professional studio, movie-grade lighting, track vehicles, stabilizers and other professional audio equipment, and post-production color grading. That is to say, when Apple is encouraging users to take photos with their iPhones, it itself is using iPhones while also incorporating a large number of professional equipment. Does this imply that Apple has doubts about the product's anti-shake function and clarity? So many comments would then say: "This is 'Shot on iPhone (with tens of thousands of dollars of equipment)'".

Also, Some professionals worry that such campaigns may lead to undervaluation of real

photographers: “If the client sees ‘Shot on iPhone’ , they might think we don’ t need the big camera crew anymore.” While smartphones empowering creators is great, it also means professionals must articulate their added value more clearly.

In my opinion, I have two recommendations of this campaign. One is Apple officially reposts works they deem outstanding and invites creators to share behind-the-scenes stories.

Undoubtedly, Apple's platform is a highly visible and traffic-rich stage, which is why many aspire to this opportunity. Everyone strives to submit better works, leading to an invisible competition that contradicts the original intent of "sharing." I’ ve participated in and observed various photography contests, some of which include categories like professional and non-professional groups. Professional photographers have access to studios, more advanced equipment, and richer technical skills. By placing all participants on the same playing field, Apple may be unfair to pure amateur photography enthusiasts, potentially dampening their enthusiasm to participate. My suggestion is to categorize participants into different groups, allowing them to choose their preferred track. They can simply add relevant hashtags in their posts, but avoid using topics other than #ShotOnIphone, as these would divert attention and reduce topic popularity. Another one is that it is not convent for China mainland users to use the social media like Ins or TikTok, and the communicating effective and number of participants are not very well, especially compared with Ins or YouTube. But Apple in China has big market: In China, Apple secured the top spot in 2023 with a 17.3% share, and Apple generated US\$ 73 billion in sales from the Greater China segment (which includes mainland China, Hong Kong and Taiwan) in 2023 (Kutlu, 2023). And people in China really concerned about Apple on social media. When I search the keyword Apple on Rednote and Bilibili, I

found the number of posts and the level of interaction are truly excessive and exaggerated, and The official account of Apple has over 310,000 followers on Rednote. (See Appendix C). And the account called Mediastorm received even more than 920000 likes for video of evaluate the new model of Apple mobile phone and 165000 likes by releasing a video about the Chinese Spring Festival that was entirely shot using iPhones throughout the process on Bilibili. Mediastorm even launched a paid shooting technique course specifically for Apple users, and it has received a lot of positive feedback (See Appendix D). And Rednote focuses on lifestyle sharing and pre-purchase research, making it ideal for showcasing iPhone sample shots and real-world camera performance. Bilibili hosts young creators who enjoy technical breakdowns and filmmaking tutorials, allowing Apple to highlight pro features like ProRes, Log recording, stabilization, low-light capability, and cinematic workflows. So I think, perhaps if Apple sets up a dedicated "Shot on iPhone" platform on these two platforms, the effect would be better than simply having it only on Weibo.

In conclusion, the Shot on iPhone 2023 campaign uses low-barrier hashtags, multi-platform distribution, and global user co-creation to strengthen Apple's image as a leader in mobile photography. It successfully engages both everyday users and professional creators, despite controversies around professional equipment use. Overall impact remains strong, introducing clearer participation categories and expanding efforts on Rednote and Bilibili could further enhance its relevance in the Chinese market.

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Appendix

Appendix A:



The User Participation Flow of Shot on iPhone 2023

Appendix B:



Picture of the film *Life is but a dream* jointly produced by Park Chan-wook and Apple

Appendix C:



The partial results of searching with the keywords by apple on the Rednote.

Appendix D:



The partial contents of searching with the keywords by apple on the Bilibili in the account called Mediastorm.